

geography of X (twitter) happiness across us counties

Thursday 6th August, 2026 20:25

1 Data

Normally one could frown upon Twitter data, but here there are actually reasons to be optimistic. There are > 10 wellbeing measures, and data covers 2012-2019, having it collapsed for each county over 8 years makes sample size bigger and provides more reliability.

right do have these for all key vars here not just in app

Life Satisfaction. Satisfaction with one's life as a whole (`lifesat`).

low: "My living situation is exhausting and unfair."

med: "Things are slowly falling into place—can't complain too much."

high: "Watching the sunset from my porch tonight, feeling truly content."

it is har to believe for us urban america, that there exists rurla america (Hanson 2015), and that in fact there are about 300 counties (yes whole counties not just villages) with pop $< 5k$!

2 Results

population 2015 decile

88-5.1k	0.35	0.37	0.26	0.43
5.1k-8.9k	0.35	0.35	0.26	0.43
8.9k-13.5k	0.34	0.33	0.25	0.43
13.5k-18.5k	0.33	0.32	0.24	0.43
18.5k-25.6k	0.32	0.31	0.22	0.42
25.6k-36.7k	0.32	0.31	0.21	0.43
36.7k-52.9k	0.31	0.30	0.20	0.42
52.9k-92.6k	0.31	0.30	0.20	0.42
92.6k-204.9k	0.31	0.29	0.20	0.42
204.9k-10077.3k	0.31	0.30	0.21	0.42

Figure 1

ONLINE APPENDIX

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

2.1 Additional results

2.2 Data Description

1) Happiness. The text expresses some level of happiness (happiness).

low: "Mondays always feel endless and gray."

med: "Trying to notice at least one small thing that makes me smile today."

high: "We reached our team goal today—feeling genuinely proud and joyful!"

2) Resilience. Capability of withstanding or recovering from difficulties (resilience).

low: "Nothing seems to help me move on from this."

med: "It's been a hard season, but we're still finding ways to keep going."

high: "Every setback is just another chance to start stronger than before."

3) Self-esteem. Confidence in one's worth or abilities. (selfesteem)

low: "I never feel good enough for anyone."

med: "I might not tick every box, but I know I bring value."

high: "Feeling confident and loving who I'm becoming."

4) Life Satisfaction. Satisfaction with one's life as a whole (lifesat).

low: "My living situation is exhausting and unfair."

med: "Things are slowly falling into place—can't complain too much."

high: "Watching the sunset from my porch tonight, feeling truly content."

5) Fear of future. Worry about one's condition in the coming years (fearfuture).

low: "I'm sure everything will work out somehow."

med: "Uncertain about how next year will turn out financially."

high: "The future feels like a cliff I'm walking toward in the dark."

6) Vitality. Feelings of strength and activity (vitality).

low: "Still recovering from a cold, running on empty."

med: "Tired but determined to finish this week strong."

high: "The energy today is unreal—everything feels possible!"

7) Having energy. Reports of feeling (or not) energetic (energy).

low: "Can't seem to get moving this morning."

med: "A little sluggish but getting things done."

high: "So full of energy I could run another mile!"

8) Positive functioning. Feeling capable and effective (posfunct).

low: "Everything feels like too much lately."

med: "Getting back into a productive rhythm again."

high: "Handled a dozen tasks today—completely in the zone!"

9) Expressing job satisfaction. Satisfaction with one's present job (jobsat).

low: "Work feels meaningless lately."

med: "Busy week but I'm learning new things."

high: "I truly enjoy what I do—it fits me perfectly."

10) Expressing optimism. Optimism about one's condition in the medium run (optimism).

low: "I don't expect much to improve soon."

med: "Maybe next month will bring better news."

high: "Things are finally turning around—I can feel it!"

11) Peace with thoughts and feelings. General feeling of calm acceptance (innerpeace).

low: "Can't quiet my thoughts enough to rest."

med: "Learning to take things as they come."

high: "Feeling calm and centered after a long day."

- 12) Purpose in life.** Acting with a sense of purpose (purpose).
low: "I'm not sure what I'm doing any of this for."
med: "Trying to find direction and meaning in small steps."
high: "Every action today felt aligned with what I believe in."
- 13) Depression.** Expressions of hopelessness or anhedonia (depression).
low: "Nothing negative—just a regular day."
high: "Everything feels heavy and empty at once."
- 14) Anxiety.** Feeling nervous or unable to control worry (anxiety).
low: "Calm and relaxed morning."
high: "My heart won't stop racing over things I can't fix."
- 15) Suffering.** Expression of physical or mental pain (suffering).
high: "The pain won't let me sleep tonight."
- 16) Feeling pain.** Explicit mention of pain or grief (pain).
high: "Missing someone so deeply it physically hurts."
- 17) Expressing altruism.** Acting for others' benefit (altruism).
low: "Wishing people well but staying uninvolved."
med: "I hope things get better for you soon."
high: "Spent the evening delivering meals to neighbors in need."
- 18) Loneliness.** Expressions of loneliness (loneliness).
low: "Remembering old friends with fondness."
med: "Sometimes being alone feels peaceful, sometimes not."
high: "It's like the whole world moved on without me."
- 19) Quality of relationships.** Satisfaction with relationships (relationships).
low: "We argue more than we talk lately."
med: "Dinner with family went better than expected."
high: "I'm grateful every day for the people who truly care."
- 20) Belonging to society.** Sense of community belonging (belonging).
low: "Feels like I don't fit anywhere anymore."
high: "Proud of my community for showing up today!"
- 21) Expressing gratitude.** Feeling and expressing gratitude (gratitude).
high: "So thankful for the help and kindness I received today."
- 22) Expressing trust.** Trust toward people or institutions (trust).
low: "Hard to rely on anyone lately."
med: "I'll give them another chance."
high: "I know they'll do the right thing."
- 23) Feeling trusted.** Reporting that one is trusted by others (trusted).
low: "They still don't believe in me."
high: "Being asked for advice feels good—it means they trust me."

- 24) Balance in life.** Maintaining equilibrium across life domains (balance).
low: "Work completely took over my week."
med: "Still learning to leave the laptop closed after 6."
high: "Spent the morning running and the evening with friends—perfect balance."
- 25) Mastery (ability/capability).** Feeling competent (mastery).
low: "Everything I try seems to go wrong."
med: "Finally getting the hang of this project."
high: "Solved a tricky problem today—felt amazing!"
- 26) Perceiving discrimination.** Feeling discriminated against (discrim).
med: "People keep mispronouncing my name—it gets tiring."
high: "I was turned away just because of where I'm from."
- 27) Feeling loved by God.** Feeling loved by a higher power (lovedgod).
high: "I feel surrounded by divine care and peace."
- 28) Belief in God.** Belief in a divine entity (believegod).
med: "Faith gives me comfort even when I doubt."
high: "Trusting completely in God's plan today."
- 29) Religious criticism.** Feeling criticized for one's beliefs (relcrit).
high: "They mocked my faith again, but I won't hide it."
- 30) Spiritual punishment.** Feeling punished by a spiritual force (spiritpun).
high: "Maybe this hardship is a test from above."
- 31) Feeling religious comfort.** Finding comfort in spirituality.
high: "Prayer always brings me back to calm and strength."
- 32) Financial/material worry.** Concern about finances (finworry).
low: "Joking about how expensive coffee is today."
high: "Not sure how I'll cover rent this month."
- 33) Life after death belief.** Belief in life after death (afterlife).
high: "I believe our stories continue beyond this world."
- 34) Volunteering.** Giving time for others (volunteer).
high: "Spent the weekend mentoring kids at the community center."
- 35) Charitable giving/helping.** Donating or assisting others (charity).
high: "Joined a fundraiser—every bit helps someone in need."
- 36) Seeking forgiveness.** Willingness to forgive (forgive).
high: "I've decided to let go and forgive—it feels lighter."
- 37) Feeling having a political voice.** Feeling empowered to influence politics (polvoice).
med: "Signed a petition today—not sure it matters, but I tried."
high: "Spoke at a town meeting—change starts small but real."

38) Expressing government approval. Expressing satisfaction with governance (govapprove).

high: "The new policy finally addresses what we've been asking for."

39) Having hope. Hope about the future (hope).

low: "Hard to see a way forward."

med: "Things might improve if we stay patient."

high: "Tomorrow will be brighter—I truly believe it."

40) Promoting good. Acting to promote the common good (goodpromo).

high: "Planted trees with neighbors today—small steps for a greener town."

41) Expressing delayed gratification. Willingness to wait for future reward (delaygrat).

low: "Can't resist buying it now."

med: "Saving a bit each week for the trip."

high: "Working hard today for the long-term goal ahead."

42) PTSD. Bothered by past traumatic experiences (ptsd).

med: "Still have flashbacks sometimes."

high: "Therapy is helping me process what happened years ago."

43) Smoking-related health issues. Mentions of smoking and health (smokehealth).

high: "Trying again to quit—breathing feels tougher lately."

44) Drinking-related health issues. Mentions of alcohol use or effects (drinkhealth).

med: "Had a few drinks too many, need to slow down."

high: "Realizing drinking is hurting my health—it's time to change."

45) Health limitations. Health problems restricting daily activity (healthlim).

low: "Catching a small cold, nothing serious."

med: "Back pain keeps me from sitting too long."

high: "Severe migraine kept me in bed all day."

46) Expressing empathy. Showing compassion for others (empathy).

low: "Everyone deals with their own stuff—don't ask me to care."

med: "That story was moving; hope they recover soon."

high: "My heart breaks for the families affected—I wish I could help."

References

HANSON, V. D. (2015): "The Oldest Divide. With roots dating back to our Founding, America's urban-rural split is wider than ever." *City Journal*, Autumn 2015.